

Snowy owl

Nyctea scandiaca

The snowy owl is a creature of the extremes, living in the High Arctic tundra. It is equipped with exceptionally thick plumage for insulation against the cold, the old males as white as a swan. Unusually among owls, females look different, with more dark spots and bars.

Winter wanderings

Snowy owls mostly feed on lemmings, surviving the long, dark Arctic winter and the extreme cold so long as they have food to eat. If food is scarce, they move south with regular winter migrations into central Canada and Siberia. Hundreds of snowy owls go farther south every few years as the populations of different lemming species boom and bust. Occasionally, they reach as far as Florida. Snowy owls breed every four or five years, with clutches of 3–13 eggs, and have barren years in between, so populations vary enormously.

mature male
almost pure
white



long
wings



- ↔ 21–28 in (53–71 cm)
- ⚖ 2–6 lb (1–2.7 kg)
- ⊗ Common
- 🌿 Small mammals, birds



N. North America, NE. Europe,
and N. Asia

▷ GRACEFUL FLIER

"Snowies" are huge owls, flying low and silently between regular lookout perches on long, powerful, pointed wings.

heavily
feathered
legs and toes

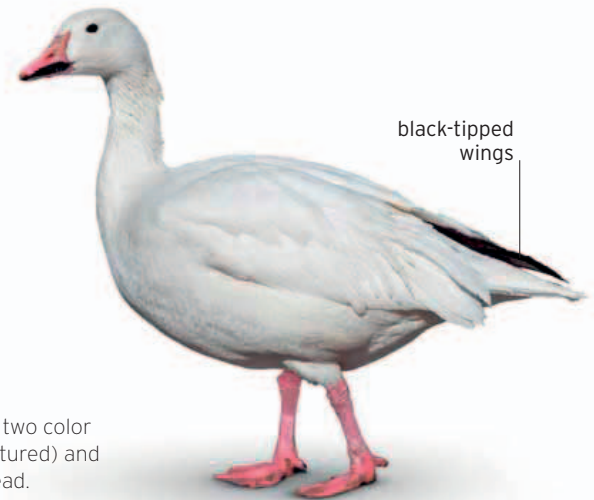


Snow goose

Chen caerulescens

Snow geese breed in the extreme north of Arctic North America and migrate through western, central, and eastern states to winter in the far south. Hundreds of thousands of them stop to feed at regular "service stations," with large, noisy flocks making a spectacular sight. Despite the danger of being shot, they thrive on agricultural land, and they are highly sociable.

- ↔ 27–33 in (69–84 cm)
- ⚖ 5–8 lb (2.3–3.6 kg)
- ⊗ Common
- 🌿 Grass, roots, seeds
- 🏠 North America; Wrangel Island, Russia



black-tipped
wings

▷ BRILLIANT WHITE

Snow geese are found in two color forms: brilliant white (pictured) and blue-gray with a white head.

Arctic char

Salvelinus alpinus

Adapted to deep water and extreme cold, Arctic char are the most northerly of freshwater fish. A migratory, river-breeding form lives in the sea, and there is also a landlocked lake form. Spawning occurs at 39.2°F (4°C). Females scrape shallow nests, or redds, to lay their eggs in clean gravel.

- ↔ Up to 38 in (97 cm)
- ⚖ Up to 27 lb (12.3 kg)
- ⊗ Common
- 🌿 Insects, crustaceans
- 🏠 N. North America, N. Europe, N. Asia, and Arctic Ocean

▷ FIGHTING MALES

During breeding season, males become aggressively territorial. They develop hooked jaws and sport brilliant red undersides.

